JEANNE SORIN

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Academic Positions

Assistant Professor
Goldman School of Public Policy, University of California Berkeley *2026–*

Postdoctoral Scholar
Institute for Climate and Sustainable Growth, University of Chicago *2025–2026*

Education

Ph.D. Economics, University of Chicago *2019–2025*

M.A. Economics, University of Chicago *2019–2021*

M.Sc. Economics, Sciences Po *2016–2019*

B.A. Social Sciences, Sciences Po *2013–2015*

Research and Teaching Fields

Primary: Development Economics, Urban and Spatial Economics
Secondary: Environmental Economics

Publications and Accepted Papers

Learning is in the Air: Clean Air as an Experience Good (with B. Resosudarmo and Y. Sun). ***Accepted*** at *Journal of Development Economics* based on Pre-Results Review.
AEA RCT Registry No. 0013110

Abstract: *Despite the enormous costs of air pollution, willingness-to-pay (WTP) for clean air in polluted developing contexts remains low. We posit one understudied reason is that clean air is an experience good, whose value is revealed after consumption. We test this using a cluster-randomized trial, and seek to document an "experience wedge", i.e. a difference between anticipated and realized utility of consuming a good. We deploy a novel experience-based intervention, installing air monitors and purifiers, potentially a more salient treatment than traditional information in pamphlets or videos. To explore the mechanisms behind the hypothesized wedge, we implement a purifier-only treatment to distinguish between (1) knowledge about objective pollution exposure and (2) the sensory experience of breathing in clean air. This will be the first experimental evidence demonstrating how experience can shift demand for clean air, with implications for public health policy, environmental awareness campaigns, and using WTP estimates in economic evaluations.*

Working Papers

Public Roads on Private Lands: Land Costs and Optimal Road Improvements in Urban Uganda.

Abstract: *Cities in low-income countries need large investments in road infrastructure. Yet whether they pay off depends not only on potentially large benefits, but also on hard-to-measure and routinely ignored costs. I study the role of land acquisition costs in shaping the net returns to 114 km of implemented road improvements in Kampala, Uganda. Using two new surveys of real-estate brokers and landowners, I show that under compensation at the legal market rate these costs could have amounted*

to 40% of total project costs. The upgrades raised citywide net welfare substantially, but only because most land was acquired without compensation. Because compensation must be paid from domestic funds that are costly to raise, a fiscal wedge, paying market value would have cut the net gains by more than half. Estimating a quantitative spatial model, I show that this wedge is highest where roads help most and distorts where it is optimal to build. The welfare-maximizing program under market-value compensation captures only 78% of the gains attainable without payment. I show that this misallocation is mitigated when market compensation schemes are abandoned. The broader lesson is one of the second best: requiring full compensation to protect owners need not raise welfare when public funds are scarce, with implications for how road investments in fast-growing cities are designed, funded, and evaluated.

Jobs in the Smog: Firm Location and Workers' Exposure to Pollution in African Cities (with V. Bassi, M. Kahn, N. Lozano Gracia and T. Porzio).
AEA RCT Registry No. 0014162

Abstract: *We show that the organization of production prevalent in Ugandan cities increases workers' exposure to urban pollution. Using new granular spatial data on air pollution and manufacturing firms, we document that small firms cluster along the busiest and most polluted roads because road traffic bundles air pollution with customer access. Even within neighborhoods, cleaner areas exist, yet jobs are in the smog. A spatial equilibrium model rationalizes these patterns, with firms capturing sizable profit gains from polluted locations while workers receive limited compensation for the exposure. Our results imply that the welfare costs of urban air pollution in developing-country cities may be substantially larger than city-level averages suggest.*

Beyond Stoves and Outdoor Monitors: Indoor PM2.5 Concentrations and Inequality in a Fast Growing Megacity (with D. Rahut, B. P. Resosudarmo, D. Suryadarma and Y. Sun).
Revise and Resubmit *at Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)* (second round)

Abstract: *Exposure to fine particulate matter ($PM_{2.5}$) is the leading environmental risk factor for mortality worldwide. Epidemiological and global health research typically proxies exposure using cooking fuel type and ambient outdoor $PM_{2.5}$ concentrations. Yet urbanization is changing the pollution profile of low- and middle-income country (LMIC) populations who use cleaner fuels and spend most of their time indoors, but live in areas with high outdoor pollution - raising questions about whether either proxy captures actual exposure. We present 152,000 hours of indoor $PM_{2.5}$ monitoring from 283 homes in Jakarta, the world's largest and one of the most polluted cities, where 98% of households have adopted clean cooking fuels. Clean cooking fuels deliver large reductions in indoor PM2.5 relative to biomass-dominated settings, yet indoor $PM_{2.5}$ is persistently high. Mean indoor PM2.5 was 42.3 $\mu g/m^3$ (eight times the WHO annual guideline), and 97% of monitored households did not meet the WHO 24-hour guideline. We estimate an infiltration factor 2-3 times larger than in high-income countries and find that the largest share of indoor $PM_{2.5}$ originates outdoors. We uncover stark inequality in indoor concentrations: low-income households experience 112% higher indoor $PM_{2.5}$ than high-income households despite similar outdoor concentrations. This inequality is mostly driven by differences in indoor emission sources, particularly smoking. Low-cost indoor monitoring reveals what neither cooking fuel type nor outdoor concentrations can capture: actual indoor concentrations and their stark distributional consequences in rapidly urbanizing megacities.*

Work in Progress

Traffic Solutions in Delhi. (with Anant Sudarshan)
French Railroad Shrinkage.

Awards, Scholarships

Young Economist Prize - European Economic Association	*2025*
Theodore Schultz Economics Fellowship Award	*2024 - 2025*
Certificate in Urban Science & Sustainable Development (University of Chicago)	*2023*
EPIC DRW Graduate Fellowship (University of Chicago)	*2019 - 2024*
Best Master's Thesis (Sciences Po)	*2019*
Cum laude (top 10%) bachelor degree (Sciences Po)	*2016*

Grants

Research Grant (w. Y. Sun et al.) (Asian Development Bank) ($99,548)	*2024*
Research Grant (w. Y. Sun) (WEISS) ($49,391)	*2023*
PhD Research Grant (STEG-CEPR) ($19,458)	*2023*
Development Economics Research Fund (University of Chicago) ($14,105)	*2023*
Lloyd and Susanne Rudolph Fieldwork Award (CISSR) ($4,800)	*2023*
Pilot Grant (IGC) ($14,165)	*2023*
Project Preparation Grant (IGC)	*2022*
Pilot Grant (w. Y. Sun) (WEISS Fund) ($8,720)	*2021*
Proposal Development Grant (w. Y. Sun) (KCAI JPAL) ($41,696)	*2021*

Professional Activities

Seminars & Confs

2026-2027 (including planned): *IGC/EGC Conference on Firms, Trade, and Development Conference*, UIUC, UC Berkeley (Development).
2025-2026: *NBER SI (Development), EEA, Uganda IX's Economic Growth Forum, LSE Environmental Week, Yale University, Haas (UC Berkeley), STEG, Urban Mobility and Climate Change Conference (Harvard), Makerere University, Urbanization and Development Conference (WB), UEA (European Meeting)*
2024-2025: *TSE, University of Geneva, Bocconi University, NUS, USC, Santa Clara University, Goldman Policy (UC Berkeley), Columbia University, Northwestern University GPRL Rookiefest, BREAD, WB Infra4Dev*
2023-2024: *IGC Uganda Climate Change Workshop*, *JHU Cities and Development Workshop*
2022-2023: *LSE Environmental Week*, *WB-IGC 7th Urbanization & Poverty Res. Research Conference*
2021-2022: *NBER Summer Institute (Urban)*, *North American Meeting of the Urban Economic Association*, *NEUDC*, *STEG Annual Conference*
2020-2021: *PacDev*, *European Meeting of the Urban Economic Association*

Refereeing Activity

American Economic Review, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, *Journal of Environmental Economics and Management*, *JAERE*, *Journal of Transport Economics & Policy*, *Journal of Development Economics*

Teaching Experience

Makerere University

Development and Environmental Economics (graduate)	*Winter 2026*

University of Chicago

Elements of Econ. Analysis I (undergraduate)	*Fall 2023*
Math Camp (graduate)	*Fall 2023*
App. Microeconomics in Econ. History (graduate)	*Winter 2023*
Environmental Economics II (graduate)	*Winter 2022*
El. of Econ Analysis I Honors (undergraduate)	*Fall 2021*

Other Writing

Urbanisation, transport and the environment: Some considerations for a more productive Kampala (with Juliana Oliveira-Cunha), *IGC Policy Brief UGA-24185*

Additional Information

Citizenship	France
Programming Skills	Julia, R, Stata, Python
Languages	French (Native), English (Fluent), Spanish (Intermediate)